

IN CUSTODY Chhangur Baba under arrest in Lucknow, Jul. 16

HUMBLE BEGINNINGS

In the narrow lanes of Rehra Maafi, a village where Muslim and Yadav families still live in separate clusters, talk of Chhangur's arrest is hard to miss. Locals say Chhangur moved to nearby Madhpur village about seven to eight years ago. "We remember him as a seller of rings and trinkets. He built support through that work and got his wife elected pradhan in 2005. He won the seat himself in 2015," says an elderly Hindu resident. "He was a good pradhan and got things done. The road outside my house was made by him." He adds that till Chhangur lived in Rehra Maafi, there was no controversy.

Seventy-three-year-old Izhar Hussain, a two-time pradhan of Rehra Maafi and once Chhangur's rival in panchayat polls, shares more details. "He is from the Pankhiya caste, who travel from village to village and survive on charity. Chhangur lived like a fakir once; we were friends. He later started selling rings and amulets, claiming that they could change people's fortunes," says Hussain.

ATS SOURCES ALLEGE THE OBJECTIVE WAS TO 'UNDERMINE THE SOCIAL FABRIC OF HINDU SOCIETY' BY TARGETING VULNERABLE HINDU WOMEN

According to villagers (and the police), in the early 2010s, Chhangur started visiting Mumbai, where he met Sindhi couple Naveen and Neetu. "They wanted a son. Claiming to be a *peer baba*, Chhangur promised them that. Over time, he brainwashed and converted them and convinced them to relocate to Balrampur district. They settled in Madhpur," says Hussain, who now lives in Lucknow.

Not everyone in Rehra Maafi agrees with this. Mohammad Raza says the couple came to Balrampur six to seven years ago to do business. "They opened two readymade clothing shops. They probably wanted to leave an expensive city like Mumbai," he says. Raza and others believe the case may have started as a financial dispute. According to them, Babbu, alias Wasiuddin, a local builder who was hired to construct Chhangur's new house in Madhpur, had a money dispute with him. They say Babbu was the first to level allegations against Chhangur, which snowballed into a full-blown probe.

For many watching the drama unfold, the Chhangur Baba case cannot be separated from the prevailing political context in UP. This is not the first time the state has seen high-pitched campaigns around 'religious conspiracies'. Whether the campaign against 'Love Jihad', anti-conversion drives or contro-